

parents will have to be co-signers for a while. By now, they trust you to use credit responsibly, so the decision to co-sign should be a no-brainer.

Most credit cards offer a zero-percent APR for an introductory period of six, 12 or 18 months. Don't abuse it. Zero percent APR does not give you free rein to use your card whenever you feel like it. Make no mistake: you're still on the hook for paying off 100 percent of your charges *by the due date*. Don't make the mistake of thinking you'll pay later. Remember what happened in 2008? How the economy collapsed and your parents were freaking out and the media were full of stories of gloom and doom? One of the big reasons for the financial crisis was that people were maxing out their credit cards and realizing only too late that they had no way to pay them off when their job situation changed for the worse. Don't let that be you.

Money Mistake: *You're Not Safe About Sex*

The Fix: *Spend \$2 to Avoid Spending \$250,000*

Don't worry—I'm not going to lecture you about sex, only about money. *You cannot afford the cost of an accidental pregnancy.* Girls, you can't afford to get pregnant. Guys, you can't afford to get a girl pregnant. Earlier in this book, I talked about how much it costs to raise a kid. You're looking at \$243,660 from diapers to diploma. You can't take on that kind of commitment when you're a teenager, the time in your life when you have the *least* equity.

To all the young women out there, I hate to say it, but the cost is much higher for you. The correlation between teen pregnancy and high school dropout rates is huge. If you do drop out of school, the future gets even bleaker. According to Statistics Canada, women without a high school diploma make, on average, less than \$30,000 a year, putting them officially under the "low income" line.

Be safe. It doesn't cost much to take the necessary precautions. You know how much a condom costs? Less than two bucks. Now that's a great investment!